



ergonomic devices



Bluetooth mice work on a 2.4 GHz frequency range. Any device operating on the same frequency in close proximity will interfere with signals and affect performance

Built for you

Relax amid work...we test some of the most comfortable computing equipment around

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Scientists have proven that standing upright (while working) and lying prone (while resting) are the only two positions the human body was built for. We still sleep lying down but thanks to the modern work environment we no longer accomplish most of our work standing up — we're in a sitting position on a chair or otherwise. The spinal column did not evolve for a sitting posture just as the wrists never adapted for the repetitive action of supporting the hand as one types on a keyboard, sometimes for hours at a stretch.

As a result, repetitive stress injuries cannot be avoided and most users are unaware of the damage that takes place since such injuries typically do not manifest themselves as soreness at the injury spot until quite late, when most of the damage has been done. For most of the office-going fraternity rest is also not an option. Take Carpal Tunnel Syndrome (referred to as CTS here-on) for example, a very common repetitive injury that occurs for a multitude of reasons. One of the ever increasing causes of CTS has been pinpointed in recent times to be RSI (Repetitive Stress Injury) that occurs after continual use of keyboards and mice with incorrect posture and insufficient rest. CTS is a painful, progressive condition caused due to compression of the median nerve in the wrist. This nerve gets compressed due to inflammation of ligaments in the carpal tunnel that houses the median nerve. These ligaments become inflamed as a result of certain mechanical movements among a host of other factors, including hormone deficiencies and even certain hereditary conditions. It is this collection of bones in the wrist (collectively called the Carpal bones) that allows the wrist to move and rotate vertically, horizontally and laterally. Once it develops, CTS can take several months to improve and any activity irritates the condition. Most of us would not even get a week away from work, let alone a few months. Therefore, as with most ailments prevention remains the best cure.

Thankfully when it comes to using computers, manufacturers of not just human interface devices like keyboards and mice but also office chairs have woken up to the fact that there is a problem that is affecting an ever increasing number of desktop and notebook users and have designed solu-

tions meant to reduce such repetitive-action generated stress, if not totally alleviate it. We at Digit have had our share of what we fondly call *technology related injuries* and one of us jokingly refers to as *technical injuries*. We've also learnt that ergonomic chairs and keyboards with palm rests really help keep such problems at bay. This article is devoted to such devices that can collectively be termed as ergonomic, or simply those designed with the nuances of the human body and posture in mind.

Logitech VX Nano: for the mobile warrior

The Logitech VX Nano mouse is the new ambidextrous version of the VX Revolution that was Logitech's answer to mobile prosumers demands of a powerful, feature rich mouse for use with notebooks. The VX Nano is small and has shallow scallops on each side that allow your thumb and little finger to grip the body. Although the VX Nano is not as comfortable as the VX Revolution for right-handed users it's obviously a lot more comfortable for left-handed users. Also the



VX Nano is smaller than the VX Revolution meaning those who like to palm their mice will be disappointed, you may need to grip it with your fingers, especially if your hands are relatively large.

The mouse itself is finished in black and dark grey and looks very business-like at first glance. Even with two AAA cells it's not heavy. The scroll wheel can be clicked and this toggles between a super fast friction-less scroll and the regular clickety-clack precision scroll that most mice have. This feature works very well and the mouse is a glide (literally) when scrolling through very long web pages or documents. The tilt wheel is another, plus particularly for us test centre types who use MS Excel extensively, and scrolling side to

side is a snap. There are two customisable buttons on the top of the mouse accessible with your index finger. These are set to the default actions of forward and backward — a boon when surfing but they (as well as the other buttons) can be customised using the Set Point software bundled. Incidentally drivers for Mac OS X are provided.

We mentioned that the VX Nano is compact and this suits its the fact that is touted as the "ultimate notebook mouse". It certainly has a tiny receiver, and this can aptly be described as "nano". In fact, sitting in a USB port this receiver barely protrudes by six or seven millimetres — it's positively tiny! The receiver can also be stored inside the mouse — to do this you need to remove the battery compartment cover. Usefully, once the receiver has been inserted into its bay, the mouse switches off and cannot be turned on until the receiver is removed — a useful power saving feature. And rather frugal it is, on batteries, that is. A set of two AA Duracell batteries are still happily running at well over 60 per cent charge, even after two weeks of heavy use. Safe to say your batteries will last for at least a month. The mouse itself tracks well enough for office use and most other applications. However, it's not as good for gaming or even Photoshop applications where greater precision is required; and like all wireless mice the odd jump of the cursor takes place.

All in all, for a price of Rs. 5,295, the VX Nano is not cheap and cannot be said to offer value for money. But it has very little competition and occupies somewhat of a niche — the über-notebook mouse. Desktop users will scoff at its small footprint and this makes it not the most comfortable mouse to palm, but it's just the tool for the discerning notebook user — compact, functional and very feature rich. A pity Logitech couldn't make one each for right and left handed users and why couldn't they make this one just a bit larger?

MX 5500 Revolution: Desktop King!

The Logitech MX 5500 Revolution is Logitech's flagship desktop solution just below the astronomically priced De Novo. This duo consists of the MX 5500 keyboard and the MX Revolution mouse. This keyboard bears similarities to the older MX 3200 desktop keyboard, although there are a number of new shortcut keys added. The multimedia